

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 23

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A taxi driver, near the end of a long shift, discovers a stranger's wallet on the back seat and decides what to do about it.

1

The wallet was leaning, half open, against the seam of the back seat, as though it had been waiting for me to notice it. I had pulled into the rank outside the airport for a quiet cigarette and a longer stretch, and was running a damp cloth across the upholstery out of habit, when my fingers brushed the soft brown leather. I drew it out slowly. It was heavier than a wallet ought to be. Inside, packed without ceremony, were perhaps two thousand dollars in fifties, a handful of cards, and a creased photograph of a young girl on a swing.

2

For perhaps a minute I simply sat with it on my lap. The radio muttered about traffic on the East Coast Parkway. My shift was nearly over. My wife, who had been ill for months, would be waiting for her dinner. The man whose face was on the driving licence — Mr Tan, aged fifty-something, address far out in the north — had ridden with me three hours earlier, and had paid in a hurry, and had not looked back at the seat. I imagined, very briefly and very vividly, simply slipping the cash into the inside pocket of my jacket. Nobody, in any practical sense, would ever know.

3

But the thought, once thought, embarrassed me. It was not as if I were a particularly virtuous man. It was rather that I had driven a taxi for twenty-three years, and in that time I had returned umbrellas, spectacles, a wedding ring once, even a sleeping cat in a basket, and I did not, at fifty-eight, propose to begin a new career as a small-time thief on account of a tired evening and an open wallet. I closed it. I started the engine. I keyed the address into my satellite navigation system, and the little voice told me, with a kind of cheerful indifference, that the journey would take fifty-eight minutes.

4

The drive out was longer than I had hoped. Roadworks had narrowed the expressway to a single lane

and the lorries crawled. I told myself, several times, that I was not annoyed. Once, at a long red light, I caught my own eye in the rear-view mirror and was surprised to find that I looked rather pleased — the small, contained pleasure of a man who has decided, not loudly but firmly, to do the right thing. The wallet sat on the passenger seat beside me. I did not, all that hour, touch it again.

5

Mr Tan's flat was on the ninth floor of a tired block in Yishun, where the corridor lights flickered and the lift smelt faintly of cooking oil. I rang the bell. He opened the door at once, in a singlet and slippers, holding a half-eaten bowl of noodles. His face passed, very quickly, through three expressions: surprise, then alarm, then a careful, almost suspicious blankness. I held out the wallet. "I think you left this in my taxi," I said, "this afternoon."

6

He took it from me without quite meeting my eyes. He opened it, counted the notes — yes, all there — and patted at the cards as if to reassure himself that nothing had been tampered with. Then, after a small, awkward pause, he said, "Thank you, ah. Thank you very much." He fumbled for his pocket. I shook my head, firmly. "No, no, sir. No need." He hesitated, plainly relieved, and then, as if remembering something, said, "Wait, wait," and disappeared inside. He returned with a packet of biscuits, still in its plastic wrapper, which he pressed into my hand. The door closed almost before I could thank him.

7

In the lift on the way down, I held the packet of biscuits and felt, for the first time that evening, foolish. I had imagined — without quite admitting it to myself — that he might shake my hand for a long moment, or call his wife to the door, or insist on tea. I had imagined a small warmth. What I had received was correct, and entirely sufficient, and somehow not what I had earned. I thought of his face: the surprise, the alarm, the blankness. He had not, I realised, been certain that I was not the man who had stolen from him in the first place.

8

I drove home along the empty expressway with the packet of biscuits on the seat beside me where the wallet had been. My wife was awake when I came in, and she asked, as she always does, how the day had gone. I said it had gone fine. I did not, that evening, tell her about the wallet, or the long drive out, or the closed door. Some kinds of goodness, I have learnt, are quieter than they are advertised to be, and a little lonelier; and they have to do, in the end, with the small private weather inside one's own chest, and not at all with the thanks of strangers.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the wallet was "leaning, half open, against the seam of the back seat, as though it had been waiting for me to notice it." Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how he first sees the wallet. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that suggest the narrator had a strong reason to consider keeping the money. [2]

3. The narrator imagines slipping the cash into his pocket "very briefly and very vividly." What does the contrast between these two adverbs suggest about his state of mind? [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. In your own words, explain why the narrator decides to return the wallet, according to Paragraph 3. [2]

5. The satellite navigation system speaks “with a kind of cheerful indifference.” Explain what this **personification** suggests about the contrast between the machine and the narrator at this moment. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes his feeling as “the small, contained pleasure of a man who has decided, not loudly but firmly, to do the right thing.” Explain how the language of this sentence captures the **quiet nature** of his satisfaction. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 4. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. Mr Tan’s face is described as passing “through three expressions: surprise, then alarm, then a careful, almost suspicious blankness.” What does this sequence reveal about Mr Tan’s response to seeing the narrator at his door? [2]

From Paragraph 6

8. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 6 that shows Mr Tan did not fully trust the narrator. [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator says the thanks he received was “correct, and entirely sufficient, and somehow not what I had earned.” What does this tell us about **what he had been hoping for**? [2]

From Paragraph 8

10. What does the narrator mean when he says that some kinds of goodness “have to do... with the small private weather inside one’s own chest”? [1]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the worldwide decline of honeybee populations and what is being done to halt it.

1

There is a sound that, for most of human history, has formed the unnoticed soundtrack of a productive summer afternoon: the low, even hum of bees working a flowering field. Today, in many parts of the world, that hum is fading. Since the mid-2000s, beekeepers across North America, Europe and Asia have reported annual colony losses of between thirty and forty per cent — figures that, half a generation ago, would have been treated as catastrophic and now barely make the agricultural papers. Wild bee populations, harder to count but easier to lose, are thought to have fallen more sharply still.

2

The phenomenon, when it first attracted public attention, was given the dramatic name **colony collapse disorder**: hives in which the worker bees, apparently healthy, simply flew out and never returned, leaving behind a queen, untouched honey stores and a few confused nurse bees. Researchers no longer believe colony collapse has a single cause. Rather, it is the visible symptom of a slower, multi-fronted assault — a combination of pressures, none of which would be fatal alone, but which together overwhelm the colony's defences.

3

The most discussed of these pressures is chemical. A class of pesticides known as **neonicotinoids**, applied as a seed coating and then absorbed into every part of the growing plant, are now used on crops across most of the world. Even at doses too low to kill a bee outright, neonicotinoids have been shown, in repeated studies, to impair a worker's memory and navigation — the very skills she needs to find her way back to the hive. Several countries have responded with partial bans, though enforcement is uneven and substitutes are not always kinder.

4

A second pressure is biological. The **Varroa destructor** mite, a parasite scarcely larger than a pinhead, attaches itself to a developing bee and feeds on her body fat and on the colony as a whole. Worse, it carries viruses that weaken the bee's wings and immune system. Beekeepers have grown grimly skilled at counting mite loads and dosing colonies with miticides, but the mite, like any well-adapted parasite, has shown an inconvenient ability to evolve resistance to whatever is thrown at it.

5

Underlying both these pressures is a third, less visible problem: the way modern agriculture treats land. A bee colony needs a steady, varied supply of pollen throughout the season — a buffet, not a banquet. Vast monocultures of a single crop — almond, oilseed rape, soya — offer a glut for two weeks of flowering and then a desert for the rest of the year. Add the steady loss of hedgerows, wild verges and small woodlands to development and intensive farming, and the result is a landscape in which honeybees, and the thousands of less-publicised wild pollinators alongside them, simply cannot find enough to eat. Climate stress — earlier flowering, hotter summers, sudden cold snaps — makes the timing of what little remains increasingly unreliable.

6

Why should the rest of us care? The simplest answer is economic. Bees and their fellow pollinators contribute, by various estimates, around two hundred billion United States dollars to global agriculture each year — a figure that captures the value of pollinated crops from apples and almonds to cucumbers, coffee and cotton. About one in every three mouthfuls of human food depends, somewhere along its chain, on an insect's labour. A world without bees would not starve, exactly, but it would lose much of its colour and much of its flavour: a thinner, blander, more uniform table.

7

Farmers and beekeepers have not been idle. Commercial pollinators have begun selecting and breeding mite-resistant stock; co-operatives now share data on hive health in real time; some growers have planted **pollinator strips** of wildflowers alongside their crops, sometimes at the cost of a few rows of yield. Individuals, too, can do more than they think. A garden planted with a succession of native flowers, a patch of lawn left long, a refusal to use neonicotinoid-based products, a small bowl of water with stones in it on hot days — none of these gestures, alone, will save a colony. Taken together, across a town or a city, they make a real difference. The hum, after all, is built one small flowering plant at a time.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the hum of bees has been “the unnoticed soundtrack of a productive summer afternoon.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the importance of bees in the past. [2]

13. The writer says that annual losses of thirty to forty per cent “now barely make the agricultural papers.” What does this tell us about how the situation has changed? [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. In your own words, explain why researchers no longer believe that colony collapse has a **single cause**. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Why does the writer say that neonicotinoid pesticides can harm bees “even at doses too low to kill a bee outright”? Explain, in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. The writer calls the **Varroa** mite “a well-adapted parasite”. What does the phrase **well-adapted** suggest about why the mite is so difficult to control? [1]

From Paragraph 5

17. The writer describes a monoculture as offering bees “a buffet, not a banquet.” Explain, in your own words, what **contrast** the writer is making between a buffet and a banquet in this sentence. [2]

18. Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that show how **modern farming and land use** are damaging bee habitats. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer says a world without bees “would not starve, exactly, but it would lose much of its colour and much of its flavour: a thinner, blander, more uniform table.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer uses the word “**pollinator strips**” in italics. Why does he set this term apart? [1]
21. The writer ends the text by saying that “the hum... is built one small flowering plant at a time.” Explain what is **effective** about ending the article with this image. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the main causes of the decline in honeybee populations**, and **what farmers, beekeepers and individuals are doing to address the problem**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 7** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Honeybee populations are declining because ...

— END OF PAPER —